1 Introduction

Thank you for your participation in the Alabama Title XIX Medicaid Program. The *Alabama Medicaid Provider Manual* has been developed to assist you in receiving reimbursement for providing medically necessary services to eligible Medicaid recipients living in the state of Alabama. Providers are urged to study it closely and update it as new material is supplied.

Please note this manual is not a legal description of all aspects of the Medicaid law. It is a practical guide for providers who participate in the Medicaid Program. Should there be a conflict between material in this manual and pertinent laws or *Alabama Medicaid Administrative Code* provisions governing this program, the latter are controlling.

The Alabama Medicaid Agency is the single state agency responsible for the administration of the Alabama Title XIX Medicaid program. The Alabama Medicaid Agency has contracted with Gainwell Technologies (Gainwell) to be the fiscal agent for the Medicaid program. Medicaid and Gainwell developed this manual for Medicaid providers. Gainwell is responsible for maintaining and distributing the manuals to the Alabama Medicaid provider community.

The Gainwell Provider Relations Department is composed of field representatives who are committed to assisting Alabama Medicaid providers in the submission of claims and the resolution of claims processing concerns. If you have any comments or suggestions for improving this manual, please contact Gainwell Provider Relations at the following address:

Gainwell Provider Relations
P.O. Box 241685
Montgomery, AL 36124-1685
1 (800) 688-7989
e-mail: alabamaproviderreps@gainwelltechnologies.com

This chapter describes how the manual is organized, how to access and use the online version of the manual, and the method for distributing and documenting changes to the manual.

1.1 How to Use this Manual

This section describes the organization of the *Alabama Medicaid Provider Manual* and provides tips for using the manual to resolve billing and eligibility-related questions.

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1.1.1 Manual Organization

The *Alabama Medicaid Provider Manual* is divided into three parts:

Part I – Provider Information

The information in Part I is intended for all health care providers who are enrolled in the Alabama Medicaid Program and who provide services to Medicaid recipients. Specifically, Part I addresses the following:

- *Introduction*, which describes the purpose and organization of the manual
- *Becoming a Medicaid Provider*, which briefly describes the enrollment process required for participation in the Alabama Medicaid program
- *Verifying Recipient Eligibility*, which describes how to determine whether a recipient is eligible to receive Medicaid benefits, and how to interpret the eligibility verification response received through the Provider Electronic Solutions software or Automated Voice Response System (AVRS)
- *Obtaining Prior Authorization,* which describes how to submit a request for services requiring prior authorization
- *Filing Claims*, which informs providers how to correctly complete a claim form for submission to Medicaid
- *Receiving Reimbursement*, which describes the Remittance Advice (RA) statement, a report that lists claim and payment activity for a provider
- *Understanding Your Rights and Responsibilities as a Provider*, which describes fair hearings, utilization review, maintaining provider records, and other information regarding provider rights and responsibilities

Part II – Alabama Medicaid Services

Part II provides enrollment, billing, and reimbursement information specific to each program type identified by the Alabama Medicaid Agency. Each chapter within Part II describes a different program.

Providers who are unaccustomed to general billing or reimbursement requirements should refer to Part I before using the information in Part II.

Part III – Appendices

Part III contains referential information important to all providers, including the following:

- Guidelines for billing EPSDT, family planning, and managed care claims
- Samples of forms used by Alabama Medicaid providers
- Lists of codes and other data useful for providers

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1.1.2 Tips for Using the Manual

This section provides information that can enhance your ability to quickly locate information in the manual. To make the manual easier to read, it includes standardized section numbering and use of bold, italics, and notes. Introductions to chapters and sections allow you to quickly determine whether a particular section contains the information you seek. The manual also contains an index and a table of contents to help you locate both broad topics and specific information quickly.

Section Numbering and Page Numbering

The first page of each chapter features a large chapter number, shaded in black, at the top right margin of the page. All major headings within chapters include section numbers. The section numbers may contain up to three heading levels, all of which are documented in the table of contents.

The header for each odd-numbered page identifies the chapter number. All pages also contain the chapter title. The footer of each page contains a unique page number, including the corresponding chapter number. Each chapter begins again at page one: for instance, Chapter 1 numbers 1-1, 1-2, 1-3; Chapter 2 numbers 2-1, 2-2; and so on.

Date Field

The bottom of each page contains a date field indicating when the page went to print. The date field includes the month and year of distribution (for instance, January 2004).

Use of Bold and Italics

To help you locate important information more quickly, chapter and section headings are designated by bold and italics. As much as possible, the section headings describe the content of the sections they introduce.

Table of Contents

The provider manual features a table of contents that uses three heading levels. In the online version of the manual, these headings are referred to as “bookmarks.” You can position your cursor on a bookmark and click your left mouse button to jump to the corresponding page of the manual. For more information about the online version of the manual, please refer to Section 1.2, Using the Online Version of the Manual.

The online version of the manual features a search capability.

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Notes

Throughout this document, note boxes and margin notes emphasize important details, messages, or references to other sections in the manual. Because the manual will be updated periodically, note boxes and margin notes do not contain specific page references; rather, they contain section references as appropriate. This way, as updates are made to the manual, you may still refer to the same section references to access important data quickly and efficiently.

NOTE:
Note boxes display like this.

General Writing Style

To make the manual easier to read and understand, the manual uses a standard writing approach that includes the following:

- Introductory paragraphs for each chapter and major section heading, which briefly but clearly describe the contents of the chapter or section, enabling you to scan the first few lines of a chapter or section to determine whether it contains the information you seek
- Shorter sentences and paragraphs that employ bullet lists where necessary, enabling you to quickly locate important information
- Tables and graphs, which can convey complex information more clearly than text

1.2 Using the Online Version of the Manual

The billing manual is available in online format. The online version includes enhanced features that allow you to access information more quickly. Some of these features include:

- Point-and-click access to all sections of the manual, allowing you to quickly locate information by section title
- Update tracking features, such as an update log and online notes indicating the exact location and nature of all modifications to the provider manuals
- Powerful online search capabilities, allowing you to locate information by keywords

1.2.1 Online Alabama Medicaid Provider Manual

These instructions are written to instruct you on how to access the Alabama Medicaid Online Provider Manual. The instructions assume you know how to access the World Wide Web (WWW) from a browser and how to perform basic browser search, print, save, etc. functions.

Perform the following steps from your browser to access the Online Alabama Medicaid Provider Manual:

Step 1 Open a browser window.

Step 2 Enter the following address in the URL text box: https://www.medicaid.alabama.gov

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Step 3 Press the enter key. The Alabama Medicaid home page displays.



Step 4 Click on the word Providers located across the top of the home page.

Step 5 Click on Manuals in the drop down. You may be presented with a “Fee Schedule/Provider Manuals” page regarding your acceptance of the license for use current procedural terminology, fourth edition (CPT) and current dental terminology (CDT) agreement page. You must click the “I Accept” button to continue and receive a list available Provider Billing Manuals.

Step 6 After clicking the “I Accept” Button, the Alabama Medicaid Provider Manual page displays. Click on the most current version or the version you want to access.

Step 7 A web page displaying the Table of Content for the Provide Manual you selected, in addition to links to the “Index”, “ALERTS”, or “Newsletters”. Under the “Newsletters” link. there is a link to download the entire Provider Manual in PDF format if you wish to download a copy of the Provider Manual. Simply click on the “Download Entire Manual (PDF)” link. After clicking the link, the entire Provider Manual will be presented in PDF format. There are icons on the top right side of the page to search, print, or save the PDF document. To save a copy of the Provider Manual select the SAVE icon and you will be present with page to save the PDF document where you want it saved. You may also choose one of the other options.

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Step 8 Click on the first Chapter file on the displayed table of contents.

1.2.2 Benefits of Using the Online Manual

The following advantages will save you and your office staff time and money in the billing process.

Maintenance-free and Always at Your Fingertips

The online manual takes up no desk space. It can never be misplaced, and if it is inadvertently deleted, you can download another version. You will never need to insert new pages and throw away old ones; merely download a new version each time you are notified of changes to the manual.

Customized Display Options

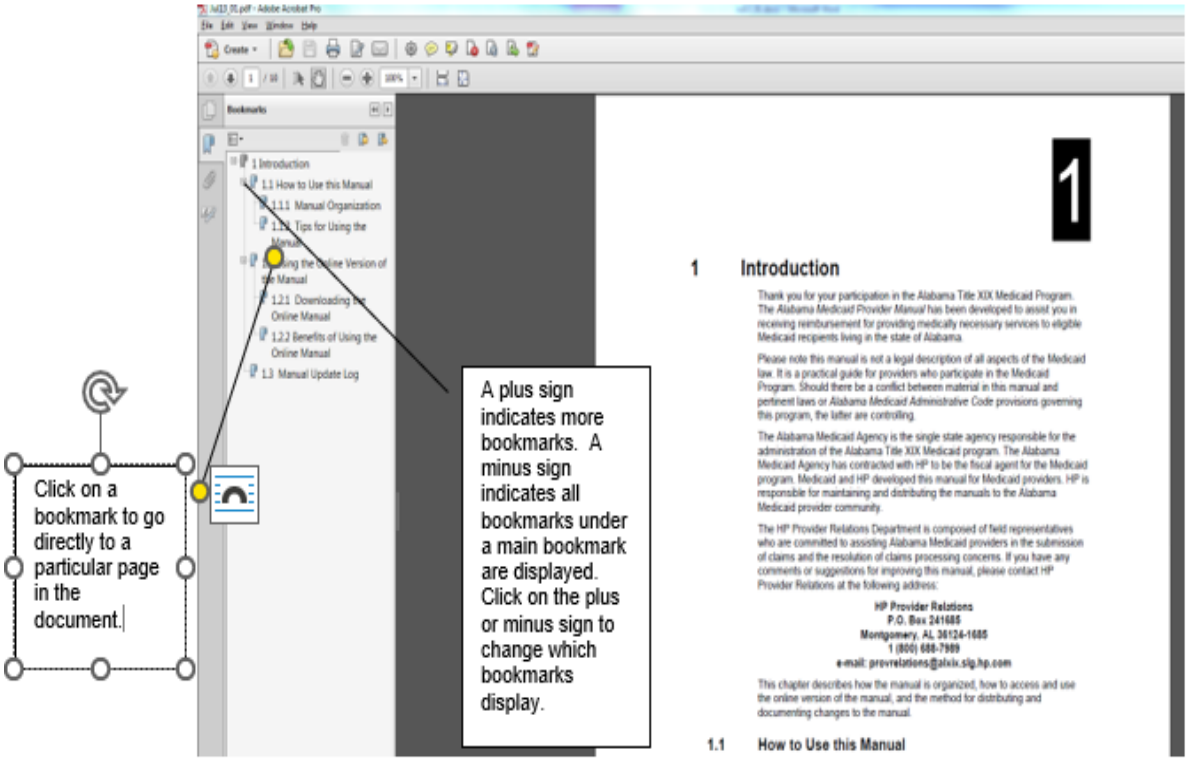
Although you cannot alter the contents of the online manual, you can modify how the manual displays online. Acrobat enables you to increase or reduce the font size, which can be helpful if you have vision problems. You may also customize other view options as available through the Acrobat Reader. The help feature resident in Acrobat Reader will guide you through using the Reader and customizing views.

Search and Browse Capabilities

The online manual features an online form of a table of contents that allows you point and click access to all the manual's sections. Acrobat calls each entry in this table of contents a bookmark. To view the bookmarks, select the Bookmark icon, the second icon from the left, on the Acrobat toolbar.

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The bookmarks in the manual correspond to the section headings. Primary headings, such as the names of chapters, display as the first level of bookmarks. If a primary heading has secondary headings, a plus sign displays next to the heading.



Simply click on the plus sign to view all headings beneath that heading level. To jump to a particular section of the manual, click on the corresponding bookmark.

You can also access the powerful online search capabilities of Acrobat to quickly locate information by entering a keyword in the Find dialog box. Acrobat searches the entire manual and displays the first occurrence of the word. You can then search again to find the next occurrence.

Access the help functionality in the Acrobat Reader for further instructions on using Acrobat.

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1.3 Quarterly Updates

Gainwell makes updates to this Manual on a quarterly basis each year in:

- January
- April
- July
- October

Each quarter the entire Manual is posted on the Alabama Medicaid website at the following address: www.medicaid.alabama.gov.

The Alabama Medicaid Program policy published in this manual represents policy implemented as the publication date. Policy updates effective after publication, are published in ALERTS or in the *Alabama Medicaid Provider Insider* bulletin.

1.4 Copyright Disclaimer

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1.5 Alabama Medicaid Provider Number

Any reference to the nine-digit provider number should be replaced with the following:

"Prior to February 25, 2008, providers were assigned a nine-digit Alabama Medicaid provider number for each service location.

Effective February 25, 2008, newly enrolled providers are assigned a variable length Alabama Medicaid provider number for each service location. The length ranges from a six-digit to a nine-digit number. The Alabama Medicaid provider number assigned is provided on the notification letter sent to the provider along with the National Provider Identifier (NPI) number.

The Alabama Medicaid provider number assigned should be submitted as the secondary identifier when filing claims for a specific service location."

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